

Is anyone there?

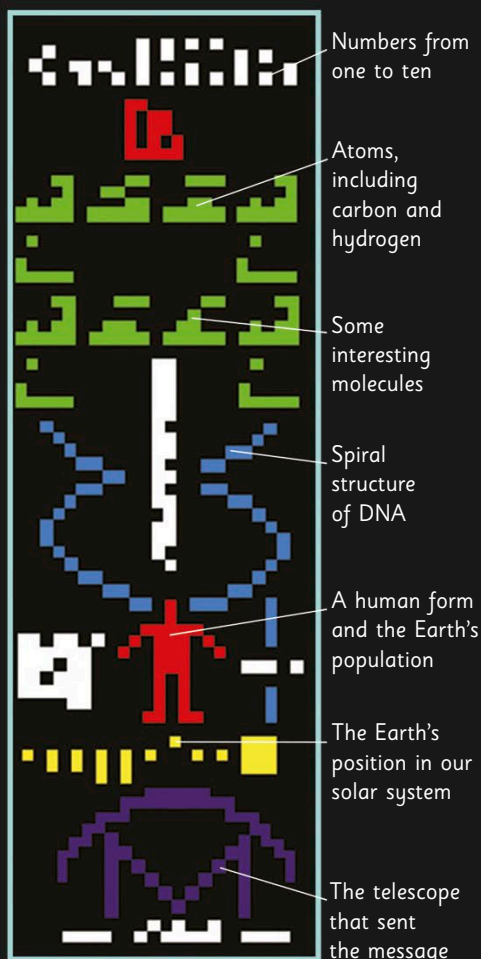
If there are aliens, it is unlikely they will speak the same languages as those spoken on Earth, so communication may be a problem. Coded signals have been sent into space. People are also listening for signals from space.

SETI

The Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence (SETI) uses powerful radio telescopes to scan for alien signals. However, so far nothing has been found.



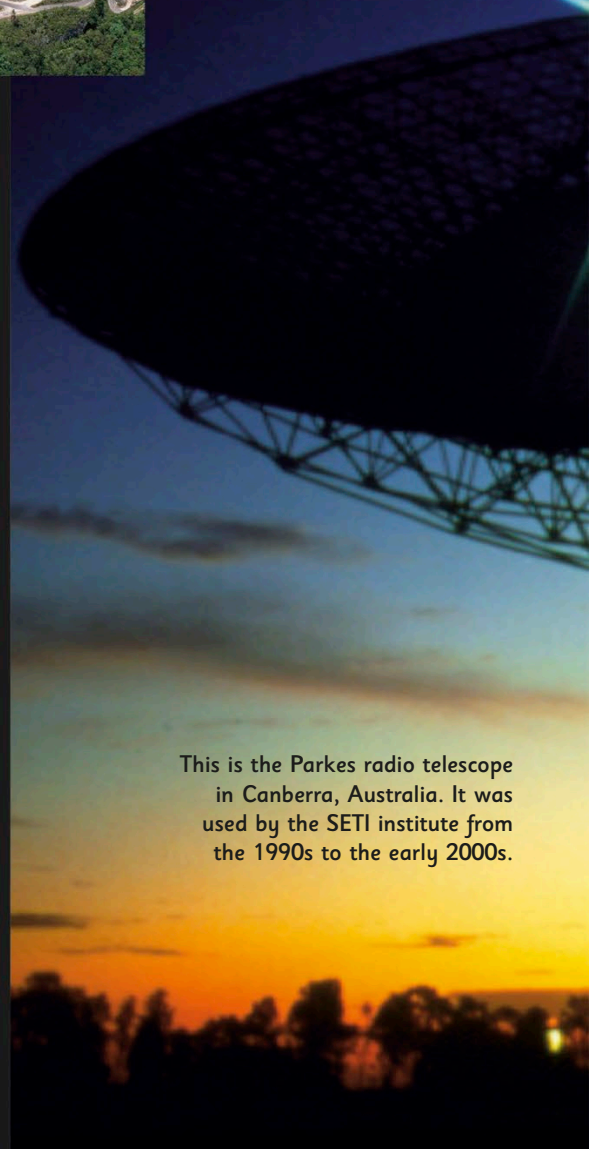
Arecibo radio telescope, Puerto Rico



Message into space

In 1974, astronomers at Arecibo, Puerto Rico, sent a radio message from us to the stars. It was sent towards a cluster of stars called M13, where it will arrive in 25,000 years. We may then get a reply after another 25,000 years (if anybody is there to read it!).

The Arecibo message lasts three minutes. It consists of 1,679 pulses, which when arranged form a pictogram (see left). The pictogram explains the basis of life.



This is the Parkes radio telescope in Canberra, Australia. It was used by the SETI institute from the 1990s to the early 2000s.